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Title of the Essay : The Bandung Conference, through the prism of Classical Liberalism and Post-Structuralism

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T02 – The Bandung Conference (1955) (Classical Liberalism and Post-structuralism)

I. Contextualization (max.400 words)

The Bandung Conference was held in April 1955, in Indonesia, in a context of growing rivalry between two blocks, in what we will call the Cold War. Composed of 29 States, Asian and African countries, it was a result of recent decolonization, and established a platform of solidarity between countries emerging from “imperial rule”(Prashad, 2007). However, the main goal was to find a famous “third way” in a bipolar world and system, outside the Soviet and U.S sphere, in what we will call later on, the famous non-allied movement. The famous “10 principles” of the Conference, had as an objective to create a new political identity for post-colonial states, within the core principles of "sovereignty"*, “non-interference”, and "peaceful coexistence”.* Using the analysis given by our first additional source, Heywood and Whitman (2023), Bandung can be seen as a gathering of independent nations, who want to establish common norms, and in that sense, is building a bridge between practice, and classic international relations theories focus. Our essay will focus on State centered theories, because no non-states actors participated in the conference. However, it was a more complex and broad ideas conference, raising awareness in new focus, such as racial equality, anti-colonial solidarity, and forging cooperation between States. This new construction was called *The Third World,* and as Berger says, it’s a “new political category” (Berger, 2004). Berger analyzes how this conference, even though all states differed, in the economical or political models, created a collective identity based on colonial oppression. We go back to the famous formula, of one of the readings, Wendt, who says that identities in international politics are socially constructed through interaction and shared understandings (Wendt, 1999). But, factually, Bandung did not create an institutional process. It created what we call *The Bandung Spirit (*Acharya, 2016*)* meaning that from now on, States will assert their sovereignty, go beyond post-colonialism and rethink the Western system of politics, proposing a new vision for global politics in a bipolar world. This essay will tackle the analysis of this historical event, through the lens of two International relations theories that are radically different, showing what Robert Cox’s showed, that *theory is always for someone and for purpose.*

II. Classical Liberalism and the Bandung Conference (max. 600 words)

Heywod and Whitman (2023), talk about conventional ideologies, such classical liberalism, and they bring up a few important ideas: the importance of sovereign nations, the belief in individual and state freedom, order through law, non-intervention, and working together by voluntary means. But how can we apply this theory of Classical Liberalism to this historical event ? The dialogue between classical liberalism and the Bandung conference is clear. Firstly, Classical Liberalism assumes that it is a State centered paradigm, possessing global power, even though it exists system constraints. The Bandung conference was mainly focused on States, in the context of growing ideology and the Cold War, in a context of revindication of sovereignty. This kind of focus on sovereignty is classical in Liberalism, which emphasizes freedom from external dominance and constraint (Hoffmann, 1981). But from Wendt's perspective, classical liberalism assumes that actors have agency and can shape structures. In this sense, Bandung is in this perspective, because, newly independent States, resisted to the duality of the Cold War, and shaped new world structures, creating a “third way”, that in a sense, went on the contrary to the second half of the 20th century, marked by geopolitical shapes and bipolarity. Rhetorical tools of Classical Liberalism, can

also explain the events that took place in Bandung. Classical Liberalism links peace to global governance, economic interdependence, and freedom of rule. The colonial rule, in place, violated these principles, because, obviously, there was no economic or political freedom which are key principles of Classical Liberalism. As Hurrell explains, we can draw a line in this Bandung Conference, showing that as a reaction to colonial rule, States wanted to affirm freedom, equality, and non-domination (Hurrell, 1993).

But, there is a limit to the proper State actions, that limited their actions. Classical Liberalism does not tend to Centered State policies, and intervention in the economy, as they think that the market is structured alone. We can see a different approach in this historical event, between classical liberalist, and liberalist, who support open markets. Liberal theories would link cooperation to voluntary work, and limited institutionalism. Bandung produced no binding institution but established shared norms through consensual discussion. In a liberal view, this is desirable: cooperation emerges from agreement rather than coercion. Therefore, The famous Ten-Principles, in the Classical Liberalist approach, would be considered non-binding principles, and not as a hierarchical authority, but more as a universal human equality just as Alexander Wendt explains (Wendt, 1999.). The idea of "common" and "shared" values, principles, are key in his explanation. In the case of Bandung, postcolonial states attempted to transform their position in the international system by articulating new norms and identities. I would personally think that the Bandung Conference largely fits Classical Liberalism theories, because the same symmetric themes echoes : sovereignty, non-interference, and voluntary cooperation. But, the cons are also here. Liberalism, as a theory, cannot explain the economic section of this conference, as well as the emphasis on "collective rights". For Liberals, only individual rights prevails, from collective endeavour.

III. Post-structuralism and the Bandung Conference: The building of a new identity (max 600 words)

The Theory of Post-Structuralism, tends to focus on the discourse, the language and ideas that helps us understand the political reality, within a framework of moving States, in a non-rational international system and state behaviour. Applying this theory, States, identities, powers, are socially constructed, meaning that discourse shapes what is right and wrong. Using this perspective on our historical event, would mean that we understand the Bandung conference, rather than a meeting in worldwide diplomacy, as a moment of new discursive innovation in an international system, in which, "new" actors, who are the postcolonial States, challenge the global narrative. In the case of Bandung, what states are doing is create a collective identity, rhetorically called, "Third World Group" or, "Afro-Asian", transmitted, via discourses, and principles (*Campbell*,*2013*). It's important to note that, following this theory, and i would argue, as the opposite of Classical Liberalism in a sense, for post-structuralist, the Bandung conference, is not a reaction to pre-existing structures, but asserting themselves as influencing worldwide policies, going as far as, creating their own structure in a way. We clearly go back to the constructivist theory, and sociology, theorized in a way by Alexander Wendt (1999), in what for him, interests and identities in globalized international politics, are *socially constructed. (Wendt*, *1999).*

In this sense, the Bandung Conference, paves the way for new discursive identities in international politics, that redefine the so-called "global south" asserting once again, their capability for collective action, assertiveness for freedom, and equality to all. But if we focus

on the dynamic of power, emerging from this conference, the actors of the conference challenged the dominant system of power, and most importantly for the post-structuralist, it challenged western discourse and its own legitimacy. Bandung challenged the dominant Western discourse that portrayed colonized peoples as incapable of self-rule or modern governance (Said 1978). In that sense, these ideas are portrayed through the importance of the rhetoric, the discourse, and in that sense, Bandung created a precedent. Thanks to this event, that material condition, to the “third way” and assortment of the “global south” countries, could create a narrative of collective responsibility, collective solidarity, what Prashad will call the *Third World Solidarity (*Prashad, 2007*).* But, how do these ideas are conveyed ? Through institutions.Post-structuralists, believe in discursive institutions (Campbell, 2013), which means, the creation of new norms, new values, and meanings, in this particular case, it would be solidarity, or, postcolonial identity. As Edward Said demonstrated, Orientalist discourse narrowed the “East” as backward and pre-political; Bandung openly delegitimized this narrative, asserting postcolonial agency and epistemic authority. (Said, 1978). The conference created an alternative epistemic space out from Western international forums, allowing postcolonial states to define themselves and their collective interests, in the new *Bandung Spirit* , regrouping to key elements of Post-structuralism: the Structure and the Agency. (Acharya*, 2016*). In that sense, Bandung, in Post structuralist view, was permitted to reinterpret past mechanisms, such as Western domination. However, and maybe, it’s the first theory that allows us to do so, post-structuralism, allows us to go back to the event, and see what is lacking. Post-structuralism, permit, to shade our own analysis, and avoid unbalanced analysis. One of the most prominent abilities of post-structuralism, is to have a look back to the event, and point up the silences and exclusions, within all historical events narratives. How about internal hierarchies, in the post-colonial system ? How about gender relations within the conference and political events? All these new questions, lies, on the fact that, following the post-structuralist theory, and what Mark Berger analyses, Bandung discourse, can be, treated in two ways : one, the institutional, power relations, within the framework of ‘transformation’, ‘reform’ and the other, the reflexivity and the silences, such as the lack of inclusion, within the Bandung discourse, under the roof of ‘gender powered relations’ and lack of inclusivity.

To conclude this essay, classical liberalism theory helps explain Bandung’s paradigm on three main aspects, which are sovereignty, voluntary cooperation and peaceful coexistence. Yet, there are some limits, where theory cannot explain all realities. In the case of Classical Liberalism, it cannot account for the anti-imperialist identity formation and discursive resistance mobilized by Afro–Asian leaders. Therefore,a part of the constructive dialogue with International Relations Theories comes on. Post-structuralism, by focusing on narratives, and discourses explains the building of the ‘Third World’ as a political rhetorical project but underplays material asymmetries among states. Taken together, these perspectives confirm Robert Cox’s insight that “theory is always for someone and for some purpose ” and in this case, underline the complex realities of postcolonial political order

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